

Agrimonia eupatoria (Rosaceae)

Agrimony

Description Erect, downy, and slightly aromatic perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has paired leaves, green above and silvery-green beneath, and small 5-petaled yellow flowers growing on terminal spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Agrimony is a native European herb commonly found in marshes, wet meadows, and open areas. It is harvested when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Agrimony contains tannins, coumarins, flavonoids (including luteolin, a volatile oil), and polysaccharides.

History & Folklore The species name *Eupatoria* has regal associations. Mithridates Eupator (d. 63 BCE), King of Pontus in northern Turkey, was said to have had a profound knowledge of plant lore and antidotes to poisons.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Agrimony has long been used by herbalists to heal wounds because it staunches bleeding and encourages clot formation. An astringent and mild bitter, it is also a helpful remedy for diarrhea and a gentle tonic for digestion as a whole. Combined with other herbs such as cornsilk (*Zea mays*, p. 154), it is a valuable remedy for

cystitis and urinary incontinence, and has also been used for kidney stones, sore throats, hoarseness, rheumatism, and osteoarthritis.

Research Agrimony's blood-staunching and anti-inflammatory properties have been established by experiments in China.

Related Species *Xian he cao* (*A. pilosa*) is used in China for comparable conditions.

Self-help Uses Diarrhea, p. 307;

Diarrhea in children, p. 318.

Agropyron repens syn.

Elymus repens (Graminaceae)

Couch Grass

Description Vigorous perennial growing to 32 in (80 cm). Has a long, creeping rhizome, slender leaves, and erect spikes bearing green flowers aligned in two rows.

Habitat & Cultivation Found in Europe, the Americas, northern Asia, and Australia, couch grass is an invasive weed. It is harvested throughout the year.

Parts Used Rhizome, seeds, root.

Constituents Couch grass contains polysaccharides (such as tritacin), a volatile oil (mainly agropyrene), mucilage, and nutrients. Agropyrene has antibiotic properties.

History & Folklore In classical times, both Dioscorides (40–90 CE) and Pliny (23–79 CE) recommended couch grass root for poor urine flow and kidney stones. In 1597, the herbalist John Gerard wrote that "Couch-grasse be an unwelcome guest to fields and gardens, yet his physicke virtues do recompense those hurts; for it openeth the stoppings of the liver and reins [ureters] without heat." In times of famine, the root has been roasted and ground as a substitute for coffee and flour.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A gentle, effective diuretic and demulcent, couch grass is most commonly used for urinary tract infections such as cystitis and urethritis. It both protects the urinary tubules against infection and irritants, and increases the volume of urine, thereby diluting it. It can be taken, usually with other herbs, to help treat kidney stones, reducing the irritation and laceration they cause. Couch grass is also thought to dissolve kidney stones (insofar as this is possible), and in any case will help to prevent their further enlargement. Both an enlarged prostate and prostatitis (infection of the prostate gland) will benefit from a couch grass decoction taken over the course of several months. In German herbal medicine, heated couch grass seeds are used in a hot and moist pack that is applied to the abdomen for peptic ulcers. Juice from the roots of couch grass has been advocated for treating jaundice and other liver complaints.

Ailanthus altissima syn.

A. glandulosa (Simaroubaceae)

Tree of Heaven, Chun Pi

Description Deciduous tree growing to 65 ft (20 m). Has large leaves with up to 12 lance-shaped leaflets, and small greenish-yellow flowers. It has an unpleasant odor.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China and India, tree of heaven is now naturalized in some parts of Europe, Australia, and North America. It is cultivated as a garden tree. The bark and root bark are harvested in spring.



Tree of heaven has an unpleasant, bitter taste.

Parts Used Bark, root bark.

Constituents The bark contains quassinoids (such as ailanthone and quassin), alkaloids, flavonols, and tannins. Quassinoids are intensely bitter, antimalarial, and act against cancerous cells.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Chinese herbal medicine, tree of heaven is used to treat diarrhea and dysentery, especially if there is blood in the stool. The bark of the tree has been used in Asian and Australian medicine to counter worms, excessive vaginal discharge, gonorrhea, and malaria, and it has also been given for asthma. Tree of heaven has marked antispasmodic properties and acts on the body as a cardiac depressant.

Research Chinese researchers gave tree of heaven to 82 patients with acute dysentery, and cured 81. Abdominal pain generally eased within 2 days. The anti-cancer properties of quassinoids are being extensively investigated. Laboratory research indicates that the whole plant has a marked antimalarial activity.



Agrimony is gentle and suitable for children.